

ASHOK SINGH SHEKHAWAT



The Battle Within

JAIPUR Routed in the previous Assembly polls by BJP, the Congress, it seems, is still struggling to recover from its defeat. Ever since former chief minister Ashok Gehlaut was removed from the state's political scene, the party has seen frequent changes in its top leadership. Somehow, it never seems to be able to strike a balance between its Jat

leaders and other party men, most of who are loyal to Gehlaut.

For some time now, anti-Gehlaut leaders have been pushing the party high command to let its veteran leader Paras Ram Maderna, a Jat leader, to lead the state unit in the upcoming Assembly elections due in November. Congress President Sonia Gandhi

IN THE OPEN: Maderna (left) with Narayan Singh

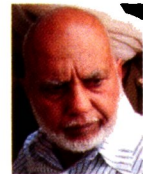
visited the ailing leader at his home, when she last went to Jaipur. This provided a shot in the arm to his supporters, who were disappointed with the exit of another Jat leader from the party—former external affairs minister Natwar Singh.

However, their hackles were raised once again when their man Harendra Mirdha was overlooked for the post of the PCC chief, a position which went to C.P. Joshi, a Gehlaut man. The Jat leaders then persuaded Maderna to make his first public appearance in nine years at Data Ramgarh in Sikar district on March 2, where Narayan Singh, former state PCC president who was removed at the former chief minister's behest was honoured. A Jat leader said that if the status quo continued, the Congress will have no chance of winning the upcoming elections. A signal, perhaps, that the Jats may well act as a third force, if the polls throw up a hung assembly. **by Rohit Parihar**

SIGNPOSTS

DIED: S. Rangarajan, one of the brains behind the electronic voting machine and an eminent writer. He was 73. He wrote the screenplay of the Rajnikanth-starrer *Sivaji-The Boss*.

FREED: Kashmir Singh, an Indian



prisoner in Pakistan's Lahore Jail after being in prison

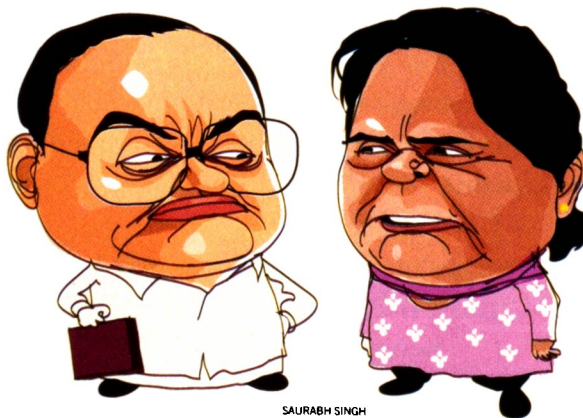
for 35 years on charges of espionage.

APPOINTED: N.R. Narayana Murthy, chief mentor of Infosys, as the non-executive director of global banking giant HSBC. He will join the board in May and will take home an annual remuneration of £65,000 (Rs 52 lakh).

WON: By **Mahesh Bhupathi** and his partner Mark Knowles, the Regions Morgan Keegan championship in Memphis in the US. They beat Thai twins Sanchai and Sonchat Ratiwatana 7-6(5), 6-2, and will get \$769,000 (Rs 3.1 crore) as prize.

VIS-A-VIS P. CHIDAMBARAM Union Finance Minister **versus** MAYAWATI Uttar Pradesh chief minister

“ This is a Government that has stood up and said: count on us. We are in favour of the farmers. ”



SAURABH SINGH

“ The UPA wants to hoodwink the electorate by announcing loan waivers for farmers as elections are near. ”

EPILOGUE: Whatever be the reason, the sop is a timely and a much-needed step for farmers.